

THE CHARACTER CONSISTENCY TRAP

A six-check scan for the character who never surprises you.

A flaw is a trait that causes problems. A character can be impulsive, or arrogant, or slow to trust — and be that way in every scene, consistently, without ever becoming more than competent on the page. Consistency isn't the same thing as depth. Often it's the opposite.

A contradiction is different. It's when a character genuinely holds a belief — lives by it, would defend it — and then behaves in a way that undermines it. Not because they forgot what they believe. Because something else is operating underneath it. Don Draper genuinely wants the life he built. He is not performing that want. And he keeps burning it down anyway. That gap — not the polish, not the backstory — is the character.

This guide gives you six checks to run against one character from your current draft. Each one tests for a different sign that a character is too well-behaved to feel real — that they've been kept safely inside the version of themselves the writer already decided on.

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Choose one character — ideally your protagonist, or whoever carries the most scenes. Read back through their appearances in your current draft, or hold the character in mind if the manuscript isn't finished yet. Go check by check. For each one, mark pass or fail. You are not fixing anything yet. You are finding out whether this character has room in them for something you haven't written yet.

Most well-constructed characters pass more of these checks than they should. That's not a coincidence — it's what careful writing tends to produce. Control is a craft instinct. It's also the thing that keeps a character from feeling like a person instead of a construct.

WHY OVER-CONSISTENT CHARACTERS HAPPEN

Real people contradict themselves constantly — under pressure, in love, in fear, in the moments that matter most. They believe one thing about themselves and live something else entirely, not because they're lying, but because they have two selves that haven't been introduced to each other yet.

Most writers build the first self carefully. They know what their character believes, what they want, what their wound and voice and history are. Then they write every scene from that first self — the public, articulate, consistent version of the person. What doesn't get written is the behavior that the first self can't account for.

This is a control problem, not a knowledge problem. The writer who has thought hardest about who a character is tends to be the writer most reluctant to let that character do something the character 'wouldn't do' — even though real people do things that contradict who they think they are all the time. The checks below are designed to find the places where that control is quietly flattening the character.

THE SIX CHECKS

CHECK 1 The Predictability Test

For any scene, ask whether you could have guessed the character's reaction before writing it — not the plot beat, their specific emotional response — with total confidence, before you got there.

How to run it: Pick three scenes at random from your draft. Before rereading the character's response in each, try to predict it from what you already know about them. If you're right every time, the character is operating entirely from a formula you've already solved — including in your own head.

FAILS THE CHECK

The loyal friend forgives the betrayal — again — because that's who she's established to be.

PASSES THE CHECK

The loyal friend cuts contact over something smaller than the betrayal, and can't explain why this time was different.

CHECK 2 The Value-Action Gap

Name one thing your character says they believe, clearly and more than once. Then check whether they ever act against it — not hypocritically for the plot's convenience, but in a way that costs them something they care about.

How to run it: If the character's actions always confirm their stated values, the values are decoration, not architecture. Look for at least one moment where belief and behavior genuinely diverge, with no tidy justification offered in the text.

CHECK 3 The Trait vs. Contradiction Test

A trait is a description that holds steady across scenes — impulsive, guarded, funny under pressure. A contradiction is two things being true about the character at once, where one undermines the other.

How to run it: List three words you'd use to describe your character. For each one, ask: is this a trait I've written consistently, or is there a scene where the opposite was also true? If every trait you list has held without exception for the whole manuscript, you have a description, not yet a person.

CHECK 4 The Surprise Audit

Think back across your drafting process. Has this character ever done or said something you, the writer, didn't plan — something that arrived while you were writing rather than something you decided in advance?

How to run it: If you can't recall a single moment like that, the character has never operated outside your outline of them. That's not automatically a problem in an early draft — but it's a sign that the character hasn't yet generated anything you didn't already know when you started.

CHECK 5 The Explains-Itself Test

Look for moments where the character — in dialogue or interior thought — explains their own contradiction instead of simply enacting it and leaving it unresolved on the page.

How to run it: Find a scene where the character does something surprising. Check whether the text immediately tells the reader why. A character who narrates their own inconsistency is a writer protecting the reader from ambiguity the scene would be stronger for keeping.

FAILS THE CHECK

"I know this doesn't make sense with everything I've said, but I think I need to see him anyway."

PASSES THE CHECK

She says she'll never see him again. She is standing outside his door forty minutes later, still deciding whether to knock.

CHECK 6 The Second-Self Check

Ask whether there's any behavior in your manuscript that the character's 'first self' — the version they'd describe if you interviewed them — genuinely could not account for.

How to run it: Write one sentence describing how your character would explain themselves to a stranger. Then find a moment in the draft that sentence doesn't cover. If you can't find one, the character you've written and the character who would describe themselves that way are the same person — and real people are never only that.

APPLYING IT: A WORKED EXAMPLE

Consider a diplomat character, written as calm, strategic, and unfailingly composed under pressure — the kind of person who always says the measured thing, even in crisis. On paper, she's well-constructed. Run the six checks against her and the trouble shows up fast.

She fails the Predictability Test — every scene, you already know she'll de-escalate. She fails the Value-Action Gap — she says she believes in patience, and every action confirms it, without exception. And she fails the Second-Self Check — there's no moment in the draft her calm, composed first self couldn't account for.

The fix isn't to give her an angry outburst for variety. It's to find the one moment where her composure — the thing she believes about herself — costs her something, and she pays it anyway without narrating why. Maybe she stays silent exactly when speaking would save someone, because the silence is protecting something the reader hasn't been shown yet. That's a contradiction. A shouting match would only have been a trait.

WHAT YOUR RESULTS MEAN

0–1 checks failed: This character already has room for contradiction in them. Keep an eye on whether future scenes protect that room or slowly close it.

2–3 checks failed: The character is closer to well-managed than fully alive. Pick one failed check and find a single scene where you can let the contradiction stand without resolving it in the text.

4–6 checks failed: This character is a construct — coherent, competent, and too in control to be mistaken for a person. The behavior that would break the pattern hasn't been found yet, because finding it means locating what's operating underneath the version of the character you've already decided on.

IF YOU LANDED IN THE 4–6 RANGE

That's not a sign you don't know your character. It's a sign you know the first self very well and haven't yet found the second one — the behavior that the first self can't explain. Finding it isn't a matter of inventing a twist. It's a matter of asking the right question and refusing the first answer, the way the Stratum Socratic Writing Method is built to do.

Write Living Characters: A Fiction Writer's Masterclass walks you through excavating exactly this — the gap between who your character says they are and what they do when it matters — using a character from your own manuscript.